

The Public Sauna-Bathing Charter

August 19, 2026

Public sauna-bathing is growing around the world, place by place and culture by culture. This charter sets out ten shared principles to guide its responsible and accessible future, and to unite those who build, run and champion it.

*This Charter was founded on the belief that **sauna-bathing is a public good**.*

Preamble: The Purpose of the Charter

Advancing sauna-bathing as a public good

The Charter advances the public sauna-bath as shared social infrastructure: a civic place built on equality and presence, oriented toward broad access. Sauna-bathing itself is a relational practice, weaving relationship between people, between a sauna and its community, and between people and the living world.

Honouring many sweat-bathing traditions, and recognising sauna as a Finnish word

The Charter recognises that sweat-bathing belongs to many cultures and predates any single one. *Many names, one river.*

Sauna is a Finnish word, and other cultures may know this practice by their own traditional names. Here we honour sauna-bathing as a living culture rooted in Finnish, Baltic-Finnic, and Nordic traditions, practised in place-based ways, and recognised in UNESCO's inscription of sauna culture in Finland. Its heart is the sauna room and the pouring of water on hot stones, known in Finnish as *löyly*. It honours the spirit within the practice and not just the heat, wherever it is kept.

Putting access before profit

The Charter holds equitable access as the defining priority of a public sauna-bath, whatever the ownership model: municipal, non-profit, cooperative, social enterprise, commercial, or hybrid.

Access before profit does not mean access without cost. Keeping a sauna running is ongoing work, and it is paid for somehow, whether by revenue, by subsidy, or by the people who tend it. The Charter asks that access shapes the decisions, not that operators run at a loss.

Empowering practitioners

The Charter serves as a practical reference for the people who build, heat and tend public saunas: a shared foundation from which each can build their own house, and help raise each other's.

Connecting the movement to global action

The Charter positions public sauna-bathing in alignment with wider international frameworks: the UN's Harmony with Nature programme, the Sustainable Development Goals, and the UN International Year of Sustainable and Resilient Tourism (2027). It offers public sauna-bathing as low-footprint, culturally rooted, community-led infrastructure that helps advance these shared goals.

Building for those who follow

The Charter commits its signatories to learning from those who came before and stewarding sauna-bathing as resilient social infrastructure for future generations, beginning a conversation that outlasts the room.

A Living Document, Held Steady

These ten principles are written to endure. The Charter can be revised when required: revisions are rare, considered, versioned, and made in the open. Any signatory may propose a change for consideration. Supporting guidance, resources, and mechanisms will be updated continuously as the movement evolves.

Acknowledgment

We acknowledge that sweat-bathing is one of humanity's oldest and most widespread practices, kept alive across many cultures. Two of its traditions are presently inscribed on **UNESCO's Representative List of the Intangible Cultural Heritage of Humanity**: the smoke sauna tradition of *Võromaa* in Estonia (2014), and sauna culture in Finland (2020). We honour them, and we honour equally the many living traditions not yet recognised on that list: among them the *hammam*, the *banya*, the *jjimjilbang*, the *mushi-buro*, the *temazcal*, and Indigenous sweat-lodge ceremonial practices. Each carries its own name, its own room, its own keepers, and own living cultures. That both UNESCO-inscribed traditions are Baltic-Finnic reflects the strong Finnish and Global-North emphasis the wider movement carries, and we commit to honouring every

tradition on its own terms rather than flattening them into one. We enter every sauna-bath, and every culture's practice, as guests.

Working Definitions

For the purposes of this Charter, we define these terms as follows:

Public sauna-bath

A **public sauna-bath** is a sauna-bathing space where broad and equitable public access is the priority. In practice, this means people can attend individually during published public sessions, on clear terms, without needing to stay overnight, belong to a particular group, or purchase another product or service. Private hire and memberships may exist alongside public sessions, but a sauna available only to members, hotel guests, or another restricted group is a private amenity or club rather than a public sauna-bath.

Price alone does not determine whether a sauna-bath is public. The Charter asks operators to work toward widening access over time rather than meeting a single prescribed price point. Public sauna-baths may be municipal, non-profit, cooperative, social enterprise, commercial, or hybrid. What makes a sauna-bath public is access, not ownership.

Community sauna-bath

A **community sauna-bath** is a public sauna-bath rooted in a particular place and shaped by the people who tend it. Ownership and governance may take many forms. What matters is that community members have genuine belonging and stake, and that the community is its primary beneficiary. Visitors are welcome, entering as guests into something built for the community first.

The Charter: Ten Shared Principles

Practice *Foundational values*

1. Access for All. Public sauna-bathing is for all people. Access means a door everyone can afford to walk through, a building every body can use, a culture where all people are welcomed and safe, and locations communities can actually reach.

2. Shared Heat, Shared Space. Built on equality and presence, the public sauna-bath is a shared civic place, promoting the health of people and the living world. Community takes work: everyone who enters helps tend it, and is supported to do so.

3. Honour Tradition. We honour and support the many cultures and knowledge holders who keep sauna and sweat-bathing alive, entering each tradition as guests.

Keeping *Run for public good*

4. Public Good Before Private Gain. Whatever the ownership model, a public sauna-bath is run for the public good. Profit may serve that mission, but never override it.

5. A Sense of Place. At its fullest, a public sauna-bath is a community sauna-bath, shaped by its place: in design, story and benefit. It is built with care for where it stands, carrying both the traditions it comes from and the stories of where it now lives, and keeping value in community rather than extracting it.

6. Community First. A community sauna-bath answers to its community, shaped by the hands and voices of the people it serves. Visitors are welcomed as guests, in ways that sustain the place rather than strain it.

Tending *Ongoing care*

7. Tended With Care. Built to evidence-informed best practice, maintained for safety, and operated on safer-space principles, a public sauna-bath is stewarded responsibly, so people are treated with dignity and protected from harm.

8. Reciprocity with the Natural World. Public sauna-bathing lives in reciprocity with the natural world that sustains it: powered, built and run to tread lightly, giving back more than taking. It draws people into deepening relationship with the living world, with reverence for the peoples who have long bathed in balance with their surroundings.

Stewardship *Shared futures*

9. Wellbeing That Circulates. Public sauna-bathing builds relational well-being, spreading care outward: for body, mind and spirit, for the bonds between people, for healthy, regenerative local economies. What we learn, we share across borders, building a common body of practice.

10. Recognised and Resourced. Resilient social infrastructure, built responsibly today so communities can thrive for generations to come, deserves recognition and support: from local and regional government in planning, regulation and funding, and from investors who value it as a public good, not a private bet.